Democracy

Class 9 Social Science (NCERT, Understanding Society: India and Beyond, Part 1) | Chapter 6 | Important Questions with Answers

Quick Revision

Democracy: power lies with the people, who elect representatives; it is more than elections. **Roots:** Sabha, Samiti, Vidhata, gaṇas, Bauddha Saṁghas; Constituent Assembly (1946) took 2 years 11 months 18 days; Constitution in force 26 Jan 1950; amendable under Article 368. **Principles:** popular sovereignty (Universal Adult Franchise, 18+), rule of law, Fundamental Rights (six), separation of powers, accountability and transparency (RTI Act 2005), multi-party system, safeguarding vulnerable groups (Article 46). **Types:** direct (Switzerland), representative (India), parliamentary (India, Canada), presidential (USA). **India:** 96.8 crore voters, 22 languages, over 10 lakh polling stations, 2,800+ parties; Panchayat reservation for women (Art. 243(d)); ADCs and PESA Act 1996. **Challenges:** illiteracy, misinformation, inequality; Emergency 1975–77. **Citizens:** be informed, media literate, follow laws and duties (NSS, NCC).

Important Questions with Answers (72)

A. Multiple Choice Questions

1. India had about _____ registered voters in 2024.
(a) 50 crore (b) 75 crore (c) 96.8 crore (d) 140 crore

Ans: (c) 96.8 crore

2. The Constitution of India came into force on:
(a) 26 November 1949 (b) 26 January 1950 (c) 15 August 1947 (d) 2 October 1950

Ans: (b) 26 January 1950

3. The Constituent Assembly took _____ to draft the Constitution.
(a) 2 years, 11 months and 18 days (b) 3 years (c) 1 year, 6 months (d) 5 years

Ans: (a) 2 years, 11 months and 18 days

4. The provision for amending the Constitution is given in:
(a) Article 14 (b) Article 32 (c) Article 368 (d) Article 21

Ans: (c) Article 368

5. Popular sovereignty means that:
(a) the state derives its authority from the people (b) the king is the source of power (c) the courts make laws (d) the army rules the country

Ans: (a) the state derives its authority from the people

6. The right of every citizen aged 18 and above to vote through a secret ballot is called:
(a) Right to Equality (b) Universal Adult Franchise (c) Right to Education (d) Right to Information

Ans: (b) Universal Adult Franchise

7. The Right to Constitutional Remedies is given in:
(a) Article 14 (b) Article 19 (c) Article 21 (d) Article 32

Ans: (d) Article 32

8. Which organ of the government interprets the laws?
(a) the legislature (b) the executive (c) the judiciary (d) the media

Ans: (c) the judiciary

9. The media is often called the _____ of democracy.
(a) first pillar (b) fourth pillar (c) foundation (d) roof

Ans: (b) fourth pillar

10. Which country is an example of direct democracy in the chapter?
(a) Switzerland (b) Canada (c) India (d) United Kingdom

Ans: (a) Switzerland

11. In a parliamentary democracy, the executive is:
(a) elected directly by the people (b) independent of the legislature (c) accountable to the legislature (d) appointed by the courts

Ans: (c) accountable to the legislature

12. The law that governs the functioning of political parties in India is:
(a) the RTI Act, 2005 (b) the Representation of the People Act, 1951 (c) the PESA Act, 1996 (d) the Essential Commodities Act, 1955

Ans: (b) the Representation of the People Act, 1951

13. Which situation reflects popular sovereignty?
(a) a law is passed without public discussion (b) citizens vote to choose their representatives (c) a court gives a final judgment (d) a minister takes an independent decision

Ans: (b) citizens vote to choose their representatives

14. The Rule of Law is violated when:
(a) laws are applied equally to all (b) courts review government actions (c) powerful individuals are treated above the law (d) citizens challenge laws through legal means

Ans: (c) powerful individuals are treated above the law

B. True or False

15. The idea of democracy has been a part of the Indian ethos since early times.

Ans: True (Sabha, Samiti, Vidhata, gaṇas and the Bauddha Saṁghas)

16. The members of the Bauddha Saṁgha could choose their leader and make decisions through voting.

Ans: True

17. The Indian Constitution cannot be amended.

Ans: False (it can be amended lawfully under Article 368, so it stays flexible)

18. The executive makes the laws and the legislature implements them.

Ans: False (the legislature makes laws, the executive implements them and the judiciary interprets them)

19. In a presidential democracy, the executive is independent of the legislature.

Ans: True

20. Indian women had to fight a long struggle for voting rights, as in Britain and the USA.

Ans: False (Universal Adult Franchise was extended to men and women alike in 1950)

21. The Emergency imposed in 1975 suspended a majority of the Fundamental Rights.

Ans: True

22. Voting alone is enough to make a country democratic.

Ans: False (rule of law, rights, accountability, participation and other principles are also needed)

23. Twenty-one states and two Union Territories have provided 50% reservation for women in Panchayati Raj Institutions.

Ans: True

C. Fill in the Blanks

24. Fundamental Rights are enforceable in _____ of law.

Ans: courts

25. The Right to Education (Article _____) ensures free and compulsory education for children aged 6 to 14.

Ans: 21A

26. The party or coalition that secures more than _____ per cent of the seats forms the government.

Ans: 50

27. Article _____ of the Constitution states that the State shall promote with special care the interests of the weaker sections, especially the SCs and STs.

Ans: 46

28. The Right to Information Act was passed in the year _____.

Ans: 2005

29. The first hour of a parliamentary session, in which members ask questions to the government, is called _____ Hour.

Ans: Question

30. The _____ Act, 1996, empowers the Gram Sabha as the primary decision-making body in tribal areas of other states.

Ans: PESA (Panchayats Extension to Scheduled Areas)

31. The leader popularly known as Lok Nayak who led mass movements against the Emergency was _____.

Ans: Jayaprakash Narayan

32. India has over _____ registered political parties.

Ans: 2,800

D. Assertion and Reason *(Options: (a) Both A and R are true and R explains A. (b) Both true but R does not explain A. (c) A is true, R is false. (d) A is false, R is true.)*

33. Assertion (A): The Constitution provides for amendments under Article 368.
Reason (R): The framers wanted a flexible and responsive document, not a rigid legal code.

Ans: (a) Both A and R are true and R explains A

34. Assertion (A): The separation of powers is essential for democracy.
Reason (R): It prevents the concentration of power in one organ and maintains checks and balances.

Ans: (a) Both A and R are true and R explains A

35. Assertion (A): Election symbols are used in Indian elections.
Reason (R): They enable every citizen, including those who cannot read, to vote independently.

Ans: (a) Both A and R are true and R explains A

36. Assertion (A): The Emergency of 1975–77 was a major challenge to Indian democracy.
Reason (R): Fundamental Rights were suspended, the press was censored and many leaders were arrested.

Ans: (a) Both A and R are true and R explains A

37. Assertion (A): Democracy is not limited to elections.
Reason (R): It also depends on institutions, rights, the rule of law, accountability and active citizens.

Ans: (a) Both A and R are true and R explains A

E. Short Answer Questions *(2 to 3 sentences)*

38. What is democracy?

Ans: Democracy is a form of government in which the source of power lies with the citizens, who elect their representatives through free and fair elections. It is founded on freedom, equality, justice, rights and duties, and gives citizens the right to vote, express opinions and take part in decision-making.

39. Give evidence of democratic traditions in early India.

Ans: The Sabha, Samiti and Vidhata of the Vedic period involved collective decision-making, and early republican states (gaṇas or saṁghas) worked by consultation. The Aikyamatya Sūktam of the Ṛigveda stresses shared discussion and unity of purpose, and the Bauddha Saṁghas encouraged debate, chose their leader and decided by voting.

40. How did the Constituent Assembly's Debates shape the Constitution?

Ans: They reflected the belief that the Constitution should be a **dynamic document**, not a rigid code. It upholds liberty, equality, justice and fraternity and provides for amendment under **Article 368**, so that it can change with socio-political needs without losing its fundamental values. Indigenous traditions and global democratic ideas both influenced it.

41. What is popular sovereignty? What is Universal Adult Franchise?

Ans: Popular sovereignty means the ultimate source of power lies with the people and the state derives its authority from them. **Universal Adult Franchise** is the right of every citizen aged 18 and above to vote through a secret ballot.

42. Explain the Rule of Law.

Ans: The Rule of Law ensures **equality before the law** and equal protection of the law, and that no one is above the law. Disputes are settled in courts by the procedure established by law, not by force or personal influence, and no citizen can be punished without following that procedure (Article 21). It promotes justice, accountability and trust.

43. Name the six Fundamental Rights with their articles.

Ans: Right to Equality (Articles 14–18); Right to Freedom (19–22); Right Against Exploitation (23–24); Right to Freedom of Religion (25–28); Cultural and Educational Rights (29–30); Right to Constitutional Remedies (Article 32). Citizens can seek remedies under Articles 32 and 226.

44. What is meant by the separation of powers? Why is it important?

Ans: The **legislature makes laws, the executive implements them and the judiciary interprets them**. This prevents the concentration of power in one organ and maintains checks and balances; for example, the judiciary can review a constitutional amendment and declare a law unconstitutional if it conflicts with the Constitution.

45. What is the role of the judiciary in a democracy? What is PIL?

Ans: The judiciary is an impartial and independent institution that upholds the Constitution, protects citizens' rights, and ensures that laws of Parliament and State Assemblies follow the Constitution. **Public Interest Litigation (PIL)** is legal action initiated in a court of law for the enforcement of public interest, ensuring access to justice for all.

46. How do accountability and transparency work in India? Mention the RTI Act.

Ans: Governments are accountable to citizens through elections, public debates and civil society; parliamentary procedures like Question Hour and the auditing of government accounts also ensure accountability. The **RTI Act, 2005** allows citizens to seek information from government agencies, providing transparency.

47. What is a multi-party system? How is the government formed?

Ans: In a multi-party system several political parties contest elections, representing diverse interests. The party or coalition that wins **more than 50 per cent of the seats** forms the government, and the largest opposing group becomes the opposition. Parties work under the Representation of the People Act, 1951.

48. What does Article 46 say about vulnerable groups?

Ans: It states that the State shall promote with special care the educational and economic interests of the weaker sections, in particular the **Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes**, and protect them from social injustice and all forms of exploitation.

49. Why is the media called the ‘fourth pillar of democracy’?

Ans: The media keeps people informed, raises public issues and acts as the voice of the masses, contributing to their resolution through proper mechanisms. Because it safeguards people's voices and upholds democratic principles, it is called the fourth pillar.

50. Differentiate between direct and representative democracy.

Ans: In **direct democracy** citizens directly take part in most decisions; it is difficult to follow in large countries (e.g., Switzerland). In **representative (indirect) democracy** people elect representatives who govern, elections are periodic and the government is accountable to the people (e.g., India).

51. Differentiate between parliamentary and presidential democracy.

Ans: In a **parliamentary democracy** the executive is part of and accountable to the legislature; people elect the legislature but not the executive (India, Canada). In a **presidential democracy** the executive is independent of the legislature; the President is elected by and accountable to the people (USA).

52. Why is India called the world's largest democracy? Give facts.

Ans: Because of the scale of citizen participation: over 96.8 crore registered voters in 2024. An MP represents about 25 lakh people on average (2019), elections are held in 22 scheduled languages, symbols help those who cannot read, there are over one million polling stations (even for a single voter), and over 2,800 registered parties.

53. What are Autonomous District Councils and the PESA Act?

Ans: ADCs are established in specific north-eastern regions with legislative and judicial authority to preserve tribal customs. The **PESA Act, 1996** applies to tribal areas of other states and makes the Gram Sabha the primary decision-making body.

54. What did Jethipura and South Manubankul Gram Panchayats achieve?

Ans: Jethipura (Sabarkantha, Gujarat) won the Nanaji Deshmukh Rashtriya Gaurav Gram Sabha Puraskar in 2019 for effective Gram Sabhas, Special Gram Sabhas and Mahila Sabhas and for including SCs, STs and women. **South Manubankul** (Tripura) was recognised as a "women-friendly panchayat" for promoting women's participation, health, sanitation, livelihoods and self-help groups.

55. How did women's voting rights in India differ from those in Britain and the USA? Is the right to vote enough?

Ans: Women got full voting rights in Britain only in 1928 and in the USA in 1920 after long struggles, while in India Universal Adult Franchise was extended to men and women alike in 1950. But the right to vote does not ensure equal participation: social prejudices still hinder women's adequate representation in politics.

56. What reservation is provided for women in local bodies?

Ans: Article 243(d) provides not less than one-third reservation for women in every Panchayat and **Article 243(t)** in every Municipality. 21 States and 2 UTs have gone up to 50% in Panchayati Raj Institutions, and as of 2023, 17 States and 1 UT have 50% in urban local bodies.

57. What is civic responsibility? How can young citizens fulfil it?

Ans: Civic responsibility includes respecting others' rights, using social media responsibly, obeying laws and rules, appreciating diversity and taking part in activities that strengthen unity. Young citizens can stay informed, be media literate, follow fundamental duties, join NSS, NCC or Bharat Scouts and Guides, and take leadership in school and community.

F. Application and Match-the-following Questions

58. Match the democratic process with its institution and value: (1) Legislative (2) Electoral (3) Judicial (4) Participatory (5) Accountability mechanisms (6) Decentralisation (7) Federalism.

Ans: (1) Legislature: representation, deliberation, dissent. (2) Election Commission of India: participation, equality. (3) Courts: rule of law, equality, justice. (4) Media and civil society: debate, discussion, freedom of expression. (5) CAG, CIC, Lokpal, CVC: transparency. (6) Rural and urban local bodies: people's participation at the grassroots. (7) Division of powers between Centre and states: devolution of power.

59. Match the countries with their features: India, Canada, United Kingdom, Switzerland, USA.

Ans: India: parliamentary representative democracy; President is Head of State, PM Head of Government; written constitution; federalism. **Canada:** parliamentary; Governor-General (appointed by the Monarch) is Head of State; federalism. **UK:** constitutional monarchy; unwritten constitution; parliamentary sovereignty. **Switzerland:** direct democracy; executive power with the Federal Council. **USA:** presidential democracy; President is Head of Government; two major parties.

60. In the 'Youth for Democracy' festival, identify the model each team follows: Team A (all students gather and elect the president once a year; the president has limited powers), Team B (class representatives elect the president), Team C (students directly vote for the president, who is also the chief decision-maker), Team D (only selected candidates may contest; the president holds most power; opposition is discouraged).

Ans: Team A: direct democracy (like Switzerland). **Team B:** representative democracy (like India's parliamentary system). **Team C:** presidential democracy (like the USA). **Team D:** not truly democratic (partially democratic or non-democratic), since elections are held but power is concentrated and opposition is weak.

61. Read: *A school cabinet had different opinions on which activities to include in the Republic Day celebration. After a discussion, they voted and the activities supported by the majority were selected.* (a) Which democratic values are reflected? (b) How does voting resolve differences? (c) Why is the majority decision important? (d) What are the responsibilities of elected representatives after a decision?

Ans: (a) Participation, discussion and respect for different opinions, equality (every member has an equal vote) and majority decision. (b) It settles disagreements **peacefully** and fairly, giving everyone an equal say. (c) It lets the group take a decision and reflects the will of most people, giving the decision legitimacy. (d) To implement the decision honestly, to be accountable and transparent, to respect the minority's views and to work for everyone's benefit.

62. Which of the following is an example of the exercise of the Fundamental Right to Constitutional Remedies: a citizen approaching the Supreme Court under Article 32 or approaching the High Court under Article 226? Explain.

Ans: Both. Citizens can seek constitutional remedies under Articles 32 and 226 for the protection of their fundamental rights. Fundamental Rights are enforceable in courts of law.

G. Long Answer Questions *(100 to 150 words)*

63. Trace the democratic traditions of India from early times to the making of the Constitution.

Ans: Democratic ideas have been part of Indian ethos since early times. In the Vedic period, the Sabha, Samiti and Vidhata involved collective decision-making, and the kings consulted assemblies, ministers and officers. A verse from the Aikyamatya Sūktam of the Ṛigveda stresses collective thinking and unity of purpose, and the Bauddha Saṁghas chose leaders and decided by voting. Foreign invasions and British colonisation limited people's participation, but the freedom struggle revived democratic ideas. The Constituent Assembly was formed in 1946 and took 2 years, 11 months and 18 days to draft the longest written Constitution, shaped by indigenous traditions and global democratic values, and it provides for amendment under Article 368.

64. Explain the principles of democracy upheld in India.

Ans: (1) **Popular sovereignty**: power lies with the people, exercised by Universal Adult Franchise (18+, secret ballot). (2) **Rule of Law**: equality before law and equal protection; no one is above the law. (3) **Fundamental Rights**: six rights enforceable in courts. (4) **Separation of powers**: legislature, executive and judiciary with checks and balances. (5) **Accountability and transparency**, e.g., RTI Act, 2005. (6) **Multi-party system**: parties contest elections under the Representation of the People Act, 1951. (7) **Safeguarding vulnerable groups**: Article 46.

65. Explain the separation of powers and the role of the judiciary in India.

Ans: The separation of powers divides government into the legislature (makes laws), the executive (implements them) and the judiciary (interprets them), so that no one organ becomes too powerful and checks and balances exist. Parliament can amend the Constitution, but the judiciary can review amendments for consistency with its spirit, and the executive's powers can be reviewed by courts. The judiciary is independent and impartial, upholds the Constitution, protects citizens' rights, can declare inconsistent laws unconstitutional and has introduced PIL to ensure access to justice for all.

66. Describe the different types of democracy with examples.

Ans: Direct democracy: citizens directly take part in most decisions; difficult in large countries; e.g., Switzerland. **Representative democracy:** people elect representatives, with periodic elections and an accountable government; e.g., India. Representative democracy may be **parliamentary** (executive is part of and accountable to the legislature; India, Canada) or **presidential** (executive independent of the legislature; the President is elected by and accountable to the people; USA). There is also constitutional monarchy, as in the UK. Democracy has no single model, but all share common values such as freedom, equality and participation.

67. 'India is a living democracy.' Explain with facts and examples of democracy at the grassroots.

Ans: India's democracy is unparalleled in scale: over 96.8 crore voters, 22 scheduled languages, over a million polling stations including remote areas, and over 2,800 parties. Citizens of varied backgrounds take part in a single democratic framework. Democracy also works at the grassroots through the three-tier system (Union, State and Local), Autonomous District Councils and the PESA Act. Jethipura Gram Panchayat (Gujarat) held effective Gram Sabhas and Mahila Sabhas, and South Manubankul Gram Panchayat (Tripura) promoted women's participation, showing that democracy goes beyond voting.

68. Discuss women's participation in Indian democracy.

Ans: Indian women received the right to vote in 1950 along with men under Universal Adult Franchise, without the long struggle seen in Britain (1928) and the USA (1920). Yet social prejudices still limit women's representation in politics. To increase participation, Article 243(d) and Article 243(t) provide not less than one-third reservation for women in Panchayats and Municipalities, and many states provide 50% (21 States and 2 UTs in PRIs; 17 States and 1 UT in urban local bodies as of 2023). Increased representation of women strengthens inclusive decision-making.

69. What challenges does democracy face in India today?

Ans: Challenges include illiteracy, poverty, inequality, regionalism, gender inequality and social discrimination, which create barriers to equal participation. Misinformation and fake news, especially on social media, can influence public opinion, create confusion and lead to conflict. Gaps in implementing laws reduce trust in institutions. Damaging public property, violating rules and indifference to public issues also weaken democratic values. Democracy needs constant care, awareness and active, responsible participation of citizens.

70. Describe the Emergency of 1975–77 and what it showed about Indian democracy.

Ans: In the early 1970s, unemployment, inflation and allegations of misgovernance led to protests against the government led by Indira Gandhi. In June 1975 a National Emergency was imposed on grounds of internal disturbance. A majority of Fundamental Rights were suspended, the press was censored and many leaders and activists were arrested. Jayaprakash Narayan (Lok Nayak) led mass movements, especially in Bihar and Gujarat. The Emergency was lifted in 1977, elections were held and the ruling government was defeated. This showed both the vulnerability and the resilience of Indian democracy and the importance of constitutional safeguards, civil liberties and citizen participation.

71. Is voting alone enough to make a country democratic? Support your answer with examples from the chapter.

Ans: No. Voting is only one part of democracy. A democracy also needs the rule of law, fundamental rights, separation of powers, accountability and transparency (such as the RTI Act), a multi-party system, a free media and protection of vulnerable groups. In the school example of Team D, elections are held but power is concentrated and opposition is discouraged, which is not democratic. During the Emergency, regular elections existed in the Constitution but rights were suspended. So democracy depends on institutions and on informed, responsible citizens.

72. How can social media strengthen or weaken democracy? How does the Constitution strengthen democracy in India?

Ans: Social media strengthens democracy by letting people express opinions freely, raise public issues and hold governments accountable. It weakens democracy when used irresponsibly, as fake news and misinformation influence opinion, create confusion and may lead to conflict. **The Constitution** strengthens democracy by guaranteeing Fundamental Rights, popular sovereignty and Universal Adult Franchise, the rule of law, separation of powers, a three-tier federal structure, special care for weaker sections (Article 46), reservation for women in local bodies and amendability under Article 368.